THE SWORN BACHELORS · PART THREE · THE FINALE

The Secret of Durose

Geoffrey × Olivia

His father told him he built it all alone. Then a beautiful stranger in a white suit looked him in the eye and said: "Your father is a thief." Enemies first. The truth second. Love last.

GEOFFREY
Swears he is still sworn

OLIVIA
Came to take back everything

JACOB DUROSE
Left a tape for his son

38	~34	LAGOS	FINALE
SCENES	MINUTES	SETTING	OF THE TRILOGY

The cast

GEOFFREY DUROSE
(37). Heir of Durose Holdings. Quiet, gentle and loyal, the "soft heart" of the three brothers, and the last one still sworn.

DONALD IRWIN
(37). Geoffrey's brother. Secretly dating Emma, controlling, and terrified of losing the business.

MRS. ADUNNI DUROSE
(62). Geoffrey's mother.

BARRISTER CHIOMA OKONKWO
Lawyer for the Hart estate.

MR. AYO LAWAL
(60s). Elias Hart's personal assistant, in prison for twenty-two years.

UNCLE ROTIMI
Olivia's uncle, who knows the right people.

EMMA
and SOPHIA. Donald's and Michael's women.

OLIVIA HART
(31). CEO of Hartwell Group. Beautiful, sharp and proud. She arrives as his enemy, and she grew up in a house full of lies.

MICHAEL McCLAREN
(37). Geoffrey's brother. Secretly in love with Sophia, and the peacemaker between Donald and Geoffrey.

MAMA GRACE
(58). The woman who raised Olivia.

BABA SULE
(70s). Cleaned Elias Hart's office twenty-two years ago.

CORPORAL IRO
A prison officer.

NURSE
, KEMI (Olivia's best friend), AMAKA (Olivia's PA), BODYGUARD.

NARRATOR
Used only for the opening teaser and two hooks.

Previously...

Part Three happens at the same time as Parts One and Two. While Donald is secretly falling for Emma and Michael is secretly falling for Sophia, Geoffrey's world is falling apart too. All three still say "Still sworn" on the rooftop, and all three are lying. It starts the night Geoffrey finds the old photograph in his father's desk (Part One, Scene 18) and a woman calls him: "You found it, didn't you, Mr. Durose? Meet me tomorrow." Nobody confesses anything to anybody until the very end of this part, where the three brothers finally tell the whole truth and make a new vow.

Geoffrey has always been the rich one. When his father, Jacob Durose, suddenly became wealthy, he told Geoffrey: "Durose Holdings is ours. I built it with my own hands." Geoffrey believed him for twenty-two years.

How to enjoy this PDF

- Tap any scene in the contents to jump straight to it. Your PDF app's bookmarks list every scene too.
- Every scene ends with a link back to the list of scenes.
- `VOW TESTED` marks scenes where the brothers fight over the vow. `TRUTH` marks scenes where a piece of the secret comes out.

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SCENE 1 OF 38 · 0:00–0:34

What's Coming

MONTAGE — FLASHES FROM LATER IN THE STORY — NIGHT

> *Quick flashes: a courtroom door slamming, a slap echoing in an old office, a prison cell door clanging shut, a wild dog snarling in the dark, a man walking barefoot on a road at night, two men shouting in a boardroom and a hospital drip being torn out.*

NARRATOR **Geoffrey Durose was the quiet one. The rich one. Before this story ends, he'll lose his company, go to prison, fight his own brothers, and walk barefoot for the woman who came to destroy him.**

> *Flash: OLIVIA HART in a white suit, staring at the camera.*

OLIVIA Your father is a thief.

NARRATOR **This is the last sworn bachelor. *(beat)* And the oldest secret of all.**

↑ All scenes

SCENE 2 OF 38 · 0:34–1:04

The Call

INT. DUROSE HOLDINGS — BOARDROOM, IKOYI — DAY

> *GEOFFREY DUROSE (37) closes a deal with three investors. Handshakes all round. The investors leave. His phone rings.*

GEOFFREY Geoffrey Durose.

BARRISTER OKONKWO (ON PHONE) Mr. Durose, this is Barrister Chioma Okonkwo, counsel to the estate of the late Elias Hart. I need you at my chambers by the High Court, Lagos Island, tomorrow at ten.

GEOFFREY *(frowning)* Elias Hart. What's the issue, Barrister?

BARRISTER OKONKWO (ON PHONE) It's better discussed in person, sir. Tomorrow. Ten o'clock.

> *Click. Geoffrey slowly puts the phone down. He takes the old photograph out of his jacket pocket: "Jacob & Elias. Partners forever. 1998."*

GEOFFREY *(quietly)* Papa. What did you do?

↑ All scenes

SCENE 3 OF 38 · 1:04–1:19

The Woman in White

INT. BARRISTER OKONKWO'S CHAMBERS — WAITING ROOM — 9:55 AM

> *Old law books and a ceiling fan. Geoffrey walks in. One woman sits alone: OLIVIA HART (31), in a perfect white suit and sunglasses, completely still. He gives her a polite nod.*

GEOFFREY Good morning. I guess you're waiting for the barrister too?

> *She lowers her sunglasses slowly, looks him up and down, then puts them back on and turns her face away without a word.*

GEOFFREY *(to himself, sitting)* …Good morning to you too.

> *He sits as far from her as possible. Silence. The fan ticks.*

↑ All scenes

SCENE 4 OF 38 · 1:19–2:29 TRUTH

"Your Father Is a Thief"

INT. BARRISTER OKONKWO'S OFFICE — CONTINUOUS

BARRISTER CHIOMA OKONKWO sits behind a desk piled with files. Geoffrey and Olivia sit facing her, three chairs apart.

BARRISTER OKONKWO Mr. Durose, I'll be direct. Durose Holdings never belonged to your father. It belonged to my client's father, Elias Hart. *(She gestures to Olivia.)* Ms. Olivia Hart.

GEOFFREY *(laughing in disbelief)* No. No, that's not correct. My father founded Durose Holdings. I've seen the documents my whole life.

BARRISTER OKONKWO We have records showing Elias Hart registered the company in 1996. Your father was an employee. Three days after Mr. Hart died, ownership was transferred entirely to Jacob Durose.

GEOFFREY *(standing, voice rising)* That's a lie! My father built that company with his hands! I have the documents!

OLIVIA *(standing too, removing her sunglasses)* Why are you shouting? *(cold)* It's MY father's company. Your father is a thief. He took everything my father built.

Geoffrey freezes. He knows that voice.

GEOFFREY *(slowly)* You're the woman who called me. *(stepping toward her, shaking)* Don't you ever say that about my father again.

OLIVIA *(not moving an inch)* What will you do? Slap me? *(beat)* Like your father slapped me when I was nine years old?

Silence. Geoffrey's face goes blank.

GEOFFREY *(barely audible)* What?

OLIVIA You heard me, Mr. Durose.

Geoffrey looks from Olivia to the barrister, completely lost. He picks up his jacket.

GEOFFREY *(to the barrister)* I'll get back to you.

He walks out. Olivia watches him go, and for a split second her hard face cracks.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 5 OF 38 · 2:29–3:19

"What Are You Hiding, Mama?"

INT. DUROSE MANSION, IKOYI — SITTING ROOM — EVENING

> *A huge, silent house with a large oil portrait of JACOB DUROSE on the wall. MRS. ADUNNI DUROSE (62), elegant, reads her Bible. Geoffrey storms in.*

GEOFFREY Mama. A woman came to a lawyer's office today and told me Papa is not the owner of Durose Holdings. That Papa stole it from a man called Elias Hart. *(beat)* Is there anything you're hiding from me?

MRS. DUROSE *(closing the Bible slowly)* Since the day I married your father, he owned that building. He and Elias Hart worked together before. But the company was his.

GEOFFREY She says Papa slapped her. When she was nine.

> *Mrs. Durose's hand tightens on the Bible. A tiny pause.*

MRS. DUROSE Your father had a temper. You know that. *(She looks away.)* But he was not a thief.

GEOFFREY *(staring at the portrait)* Then why do I feel like everybody in this house is lying to me?

> *He walks out. His mother looks up at the portrait of her husband, and she looks afraid.*

↑ All scenes

SCENE 6 OF 38 · 3:19–3:30

The Documents

INT. JACOB DUROSE'S OLD OFFICE — NIGHT

> *The dusty office from Part One. Geoffrey pulls files from a steel cabinet and finds a leather folder marked "CERTIFICATE OF INCORPORATION — DUROSE HOLDINGS — 1996 — FOUNDER: JACOB DUROSE."*

GEOFFREY *(relieved, almost laughing)* There. There it is. Papa, I knew it.

> *He holds it up to the lamp. His father's signature. A government seal. He doesn't see the tiny smudge under the founder's name.*

↑ All scenes

SCENE 7 OF 38 · 3:30–3:57 TRUTH

Forged

INT. BARRISTER OKONKWO'S OFFICE — NEXT DAY

Geoffrey and his lawyer, MR. BANJO, sit across from Olivia and Barrister Okonkwo. Geoffrey slides the leather folder across the table.

GEOFFREY My father's certificate. 1996. Founder: Jacob Durose. Read it.

Olivia barely glances at it.

OLIVIA It's fake.

GEOFFREY It has a government seal!

OLIVIA So does every fake in Lagos. *(She slides it to Barrister Okonkwo.)* Check it.

The barrister holds the paper under a small UV lamp. Under the purple light, a second name glows faintly beneath "JACOB DUROSE," scraped away and typed over: "ELIAS HART."

BARRISTER OKONKWO *(quietly)* The original name was removed and typed over, Mr. Durose. This document is forged.

Geoffrey stares at the glowing letters. He can't speak.

MR. BANJO *(whispering)* Sir… I think we should go.

Geoffrey stands slowly, as if he's aged ten years, and walks out. Olivia watches him and doesn't look like she's won anything.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 8 OF 38 · 3:57–4:33

Lockdown

EXT. DUROSE HOLDINGS HEADQUARTERS, IKOYI — MORNING

Court officials and police tape seal the glass doors. A notice is pasted on them: "SEALED BY ORDER OF THE HIGH COURT OF LAGOS STATE." Staff stand outside, confused. Geoffrey's car pulls up, and right behind it, Donald's Range Rover and Michael's G-Wagon.

DONALD *(jumping out)* Geoffrey! What is this? The banks just froze Three Boys Ventures! Durose Holdings carries a third of everything we own together!

MICHAEL My studio's account is frozen too! I have a crew of two hundred waiting to be paid!

COURT OFFICIAL Sirs, the court has sealed this company pending a claim of ownership. The claimant says Jacob Durose was never the owner.

DONALD *(turning slowly to Geoffrey)* Never the owner?

Geoffrey looks at the sealed doors, at his father's name on the gate and at his brothers. He doesn't say a word. He gets back into his car and drives away.

MICHAEL Geoffrey! GEOFFREY!

↑ All scenes

SCENE 9 OF 38 · 4:33–5:18 VOW TESTED

"Who Wants to Fall in Love?"

INT. GEOFFREY'S HOUSE, BANANA ISLAND — NIGHT

> *Geoffrey sits in the dark with a drink. Donald and Michael let themselves in. Geoffrey tells them everything.*

GEOFFREY A forged certificate. My father's handwriting, over another man's name. Twenty-two years, and I've been sitting in a stolen chair.

MICHAEL *(gently)* You didn't know.

DONALD *(pacing)* Knowing doesn't matter to the banks, Michael. We have billions tied to that company.

GEOFFREY *(laughing bitterly)* And her. Olivia Hart. She called my father a thief to my face. *(He raises his glass.)* This is why I'm grateful for that vow. Who on God's earth wants to fall in love? With a woman like that? Rude. Proud. Cruel. *(beat)* Thank God for rule four.

> *Behind him, Donald and Michael slowly look at each other. Donald has a size thirty-eight heel hidden in his kitchen. Michael has "Script Supervisor" calling him at 2 a.m. They already know about each other. Neither says a word.*

MICHAEL *(clearing his throat)* ...Yes. Rule four. Very... important rule.

DONALD *(sipping his drink)* Very.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 10 OF 38 · 5:18–5:58

The Woman who Raised Her

INT. OLIVIA'S PENTHOUSE, IKOYI — NIGHT

> *Olivia sits on the balcony, her heels kicked off. MAMA GRACE (58), gentle, brings her tea.*

MAMA GRACE You won today. Why do you look like you lost?

OLIVIA *(staring at the city)* Because of his face, Mama, when the lawyer showed him the forgery. He really didn't know. *(beat)* I watched something die in his eyes.

MAMA GRACE You've waited twenty-two years for the truth, my daughter.

OLIVIA I wanted the truth. I didn't want to break a man who was lied to the same way I was. *(She sets down the tea.)* I'm going to see him.

MAMA GRACE At this hour?

OLIVIA Tomorrow. *(beat)* Before I lose my courage.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 11 OF 38 · 5:58–7:45

The Slap

INT. GEOFFREY'S HOUSE — FRONT DOOR / SITTING ROOM — NEXT DAY

A knock. Geoffrey opens the door, unshaven and in a T-shirt. Olivia stands there without the sunglasses or the white suit, just a simple dress.

GEOFFREY *(stunned)* How do you know where I live?

OLIVIA I asked a friend who knows a friend. This is Lagos. *(beat)* May I come in?

Inside, they sit at opposite ends of the sofa.

OLIVIA I came to say I'm sorry. For "thief." I was angry for twenty-two years and I threw all of it at you.

GEOFFREY *(quietly)* It's alright. *(beat)* But I need to ask you something. You said my father slapped you. When?

She looks at her hands for a long moment.

OLIVIA I was nine. I found your father alone in Papa's office, going through Papa's papers. I said, "Uncle Jacob, why are you touching Papa's things?" *(beat)* He slapped me so hard I fell. Then he whispered, "If you ever tell your father, you'll regret the day you were born." *(beat)* Papa died three weeks later. I never told anyone.

Geoffrey closes his eyes. His jaw shakes.

GEOFFREY I'm sorry. *(His voice breaks.)* I'm so sorry my father did that to you. I didn't know. I swear to God, I didn't know.

OLIVIA I know. *(beat)* My father lied to me too, Geoffrey. He beat the woman who raised me. He hid things from me my whole childhood. *(She smiles sadly.)* I forgot you might be going through the same thing. I'm sorry for that too.

A long silence. Two children of liars, sitting on one sofa.

GEOFFREY Then let's stop guessing. Let's go to the bottom of this. Both of us. Whatever the truth is, even if it's ugly.

OLIVIA *(after a beat)* I know where to start. There's an old man, Baba Sule. He cleaned my father's office when Papa was alive. He saw everything.

GEOFFREY Then we'll go and see Baba Sule.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 12 OF 38 · 7:45–9:17 VOW TESTED

"Brother, You Made a Vow"

EXT. THREE BOYS VENTURES — CAR PARK, IKOYI — MORNING

Donald and Michael stand by their cars. Geoffrey arrives with a travel bag.

GEOFFREY I'm going on a trip. A few days. I need to clear my head.

DONALD *(exploding)* A TRIP? The banks have frozen us and you're going on a TRIP? Do you know how much WE put into that company?

MICHAEL Donald, calm down. Calm down. *(to Geoffrey)* What kind of trip? Vacation?

GEOFFREY I'm going to prove the company belongs to my father. That's all. I'm going to get it back for all of us.

MICHAEL *(relaxing)* Okay. Okay, that's good. Is that all?

GEOFFREY That's all.

A huge black SUV glides into the car park. The rear window slides down. Olivia leans out, smiling.

OLIVIA Geoffrey! I'm here. Are you ready?

Donald and Michael turn very, very slowly to look at Geoffrey.

DONALD *(dangerously quiet)* Brother. You made a vow.

GEOFFREY Calm down. Calm down! I'm not doing anything with her. We're going to find the truth, that's all.

MICHAEL "We"? You and the woman who froze our accounts?

DONALD Are you about to sell the company to her? Is that it?

GEOFFREY I'm not selling anything! I'm still in the vow. No woman can shake me. *(firm)* I'm proving this business belongs to my father. Nothing more. I know my father. I believe him.

A long, tense beat.

MICHAEL Fine. Just stay in touch with us.

Donald gets into his car and slams the door without another word. Michael follows. Geoffrey walks to the SUV and gets in beside Olivia.

OLIVIA *(watching the cars leave)* Wow. Is that how your friends talk to you? *(beat)* That's toxic, Geoffrey. Nobody should talk to you like that.

GEOFFREY *(quietly)* They're my brothers. That's just how they talk.

OLIVIA *(quietly)* That's not an answer.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 13 OF 38 · 9:17–10:17 TRUTH

Baba Sule

EXT. BABA SULE'S COMPOUND, ABEOKUTA — DAY

A small, neat compound under a mango tree. BABA SULE (70s) sits on a bench with a walking stick. Olivia kneels to greet him in the traditional way. Geoffrey bows.

BABA SULE *(squinting)* Olivia? Little Olivia Hart? *(He laughs and takes her face in his hands.)* You used to steal sugar from the office tea tray!

OLIVIA *(laughing)* Baba, you never reported me.

BABA SULE *(turning to Geoffrey and going cold)* And this one has his father's face. *(beat)* Jacob's son.

GEOFFREY Yes, Baba. I've come for the truth. Even if it's about my father.

BABA SULE *(after a long pause)* I left that office because Jacob Durose fired me. Two weeks after Elias died. He said I was "too old to clean." *(He taps his stick.)* I was forty-eight.

GEOFFREY Were they partners, Baba? My father and Mr. Hart?

BABA SULE Partners? *(He laughs sadly.)* My son, Elias Hart owned that company. Your father was his clerk. He worked like a donkey for fifteen years, and every year Elias promised him shares. "Next year, Jacob." *(beat)* He never gave him one.

Geoffrey sits down slowly on the bench. He takes out the photograph: "Jacob & Elias. Partners forever. 1998."

GEOFFREY *(whispering)* He wrote "partners" on a photograph. And never on a contract.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 14 OF 38 · 10:17–11:31

A Home of Lies

INT. SMALL RESTAURANT, ABEOKUTA — EVENING

A quiet local restaurant with plates of amala and ewedu and a ceiling fan. Geoffrey and Olivia eat, and for the first time they're relaxed.

OLIVIA You eat amala like a man who's never seen food.

GEOFFREY I grew up in Ajegunle before my father got rich. Amala was a Sunday luxury.

OLIVIA *(surprised)* You? Ajegunle? I thought you were born with a silver spoon.

GEOFFREY Plastic spoon. The silver one arrived when I was fifteen, the week my father said "something happened." *(beat)* Now I know what happened. Your father died.

Olivia puts down her spoon.

OLIVIA Want to know the biggest lie of my life? The woman who raised me isn't my mother. At fifteen, I found a lawyer's letter in Papa's drawer. My real mother died giving birth to me. And my grandfather had left me an island in the Lekki lagoon. Papa hid both from me.

GEOFFREY *(softly)* Fifteen. That's when my father's lies began, and yours ended.

OLIVIA We grew up in two houses full of lies, Geoffrey. Different houses. Same lies.

A comfortable silence falls between them.

GEOFFREY *(clearing his throat)* Would you… like to hang out some more? After this?

OLIVIA *(raising an eyebrow, smiling)* Are we not hanging out right now?

↑ All scenes

SCENE 15 OF 38 · 11:31–11:52

The Shoes

EXT. ABEOKUTA STREET — NIGHT

> *A long road under streetlights. They walk slowly back to the hotel, talking and laughing. Olivia winces with every step. Her very high heels are killing her.*

GEOFFREY You're limping.

OLIVIA I'm fine. CEOs don't limp.

GEOFFREY *(stopping)* Sit.

> *He sits her down on a low wall, kneels and takes off his own shoes and socks.*

OLIVIA Geoffrey, what are you doing?

GEOFFREY *(gently removing her heels and slipping his shoes onto her feet)* They're too big. But they're flat.

OLIVIA And you?

GEOFFREY *(standing barefoot on the road, holding her heels)* I grew up in Ajegunle. My feet remember.

> *They walk on. She shuffles in his giant shoes, laughing. He walks barefoot beside her, carrying her heels. She can't stop smiling.*

↑ All scenes

SCENE 16 OF 38 · 11:52–12:34

"I Think I'm Falling"

INT. HOTEL — OLIVIA'S ROOM / GEOFFREY'S ROOM — NIGHT — SPLIT SCREEN

LEFT: Olivia lies on the bed, still wearing his shoes, on the phone with her best friend KEMI.

OLIVIA Kemi. He gave me his shoes. He walked home barefoot. A billionaire, barefoot on the road in Abeokuta.

KEMI
ON PHONE
Olivia Hart. Are you smiling? I can HEAR you smiling!

OLIVIA *(covering her face)* I think… I think I'm falling in love with him, Kemi. The son of the man who slapped me. What is wrong with me?

RIGHT: Geoffrey stands at the bathroom mirror, staring at himself.

GEOFFREY *(to his reflection)* You are NOT falling for this girl. *(beat)* She's beautiful. She's brilliant. She understands you without a word. *(He grips the sink.)* And you made a vow. With your brothers.

He looks down at his dusty bare feet and smiles anyway.

GEOFFREY …Oh, God.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 17 OF 38 · 12:34–13:22 VOW TESTED

The Prison Gate

EXT. AGODI CORRECTIONAL CENTRE, IBADAN — WAITING AREA — DAY

> *A dusty waiting area with long benches. Baba Sule told them that Elias Hart's personal assistant, Mr. Ayo Lawal, has been in this prison for twenty-two years. Olivia and Geoffrey sit and wait. Geoffrey's phone rings: DONALD.*

GEOFFREY *(standing)* Excuse me. I have to take this.

> *He walks to the far end of the yard.*

GEOFFREY Donald.

DONALD ON PHONE Where are you? Have you proved it yet? Have you shown that girl the company is your father's?

GEOFFREY I'm working on it. Calm down.

DONALD ON PHONE I'm serious, Geoffrey. She picked you up in her car. Same hotel. Are you dating her?

GEOFFREY I am NOT dating her! I'm still in the vow! *(beat)* And Donald? I hate the way you talk to me. You don't know how to talk to me.

DONALD ON PHONE *(scoffing)* Oh. Oh, now she's told you that too? "Toxic"? I can hear her words in your mouth, Geoffrey—

> *Geoffrey hangs up and switches the phone off.*

↑ All scenes

SCENE 18 OF 38 · 13:22–14:04

Corporal Iro

EXT. PRISON WAITING AREA — CONTINUOUS

A prison officer, CORPORAL IRO, sits down far too close to Olivia.

CORPORAL IRO Fine girl. You're too beautiful for this kind of place. Give me your number. I'll make sure you see your person quickly.

OLIVIA *(moving away)* No, thank you.

CORPORAL IRO *(grabbing her wrist)* Ah-ah! Why are you forming? Just your number—

OLIVIA Leave me alone! Get your hands off me!

Across the yard, Geoffrey turns at her scream. He runs, grabs the officer by the collar, pulls him off Olivia and shoves him hard to the ground.

GEOFFREY Don't you EVER touch her!

Whistles blow. Four officers rush in and tackle Geoffrey to the ground, beating him with batons.

OLIVIA Stop! STOP! He was protecting me! Let him go!

CORPORAL IRO *(dusting himself off, sneering)* He assaulted an officer of the state. He'll sleep inside today. And tomorrow. And the day after.

They drag Geoffrey away. He looks back at Olivia, bleeding from his lip.

GEOFFREY *(calling out)* Are you hurt? Olivia! Are you hurt?

The steel gate clangs shut.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 19 OF 38 · 14:04–14:32

Three Days

INT. PRISON CELL — NIGHT / INT. OLIVIA'S SUV — NIGHT — INTERCUT

A crowded, dark cell. Geoffrey sits against the wall with bruises on his face, still barefoot because they took his shoes at the gate.

In her SUV, Olivia is on the phone, crying and furious, while her BODYGUARD drives.

OLIVIA Uncle Rotimi, please. They've had him for a day. They're beating him. I don't care who you call. Call the Controller-General. Call the governor. Call God!

UNCLE ROTIMI (ON PHONE) Calm down, my daughter. I know the Controller. I'll make the call tonight. But who is this man to you?

Olivia doesn't answer.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 20 OF 38 · 14:32–16:22 VOW TESTED

Brothers at War

INT. THREE BOYS VENTURES — BOARDROOM — DAY — DAY THREE

Donald paces with his phone to his ear while Michael sits.

DONALD Third day. Not one call. *(He throws the phone down.)* I KNEW it. He's fallen for her.

MICHAEL Calm down, Donald. Geoffrey won't do that. Not with the business on the line.

DONALD Geoffrey has the softest heart of the three of us! You know it! A woman like that eats a soft heart for breakfast!

MICHAEL *(standing)* Okay, he does. And so what?

DONALD *(narrowing his eyes)* Oh. Oh, I see what you're doing. You're defending him because you've got your own girl. "Script Supervisor."

MICHAEL *(not missing a beat)* And what's Emma to you?

DONALD *(freezing)* …What? You think I'm falling for Emma?

MICHAEL I don't know. You tell me.

DONALD I can't have this conversation with you right now.

MICHAEL Oh, really? Then have THIS one. If this business falls, you'll owe me and Geoffrey, because we put more money into Durose than you did. You did nothing but take Emma on fancy dates!

DONALD When have you EVER seen me on a date with Emma?

MICHAEL I haven't. But it looks like that's where we're heading, Chairman.

DONALD *(grabbing his keys)* I can't do this with you, Michael.

MICHAEL Why not? Do it with me!

DONALD This is nonsense!

He storms out.

INT. DONALD'S CAR — MOMENTS LATER. Donald grips the wheel, breathing hard.

DONALD *(to himself)* He knows. He knows about Emma. *(beat)* No. He's guessing. Michael always guesses. *(He hits the steering wheel.)* Are they going to find out? Are they going to find out I'm dating Emma?

His phone lights up: "E. Reardon." He stares at it, then answers softly.

EMMA Hi, you.
ON PHONE

DONALD *(quietly)* Emma. Am I becoming the man who stops his brother from being happy, just so nobody finds out I'm happy too?

EMMA
ON PHONE *(gently)* You're becoming a man who's scared. *(beat)* But Donald, from the outside those look exactly the same.

> *Donald closes his eyes.*

↑ All scenes

SCENE 21 OF 38 · 16:22–16:47

Released

EXT. AGODI CORRECTIONAL CENTRE — GATE — NIGHT

> *The gate opens. Geoffrey limps out, bruised and filthy, and still barefoot. Olivia runs to him. Uncle Rotimi stands by the cars.*

OLIVIA *(rushing to him)* Look what they did to you. Look what I did to you.

GEOFFREY *(weakly smiling)* You didn't do anything. *(beat)* Did he touch you again? After I was gone?

OLIVIA *(crying)* Three days in a cell, and that's your first question?

GEOFFREY It's the only question.

> *His knees buckle. She catches him.*

OLIVIA *(shouting)* Hospital! NOW!

↑ All scenes

SCENE 22 OF 38 · 16:47–17:50

"She's Not My Woman"

INT. PRIVATE HOSPITAL ROOM, IBADAN — DAY

Geoffrey lies in bed with a drip in his arm. Olivia sits beside him, spoon-feeding him pepper soup she cooked herself.

GEOFFREY I can feed myself.

OLIVIA You can't even lift a cup. Open.

He opens his mouth obediently. A NURSE enters and checks his vitals.

NURSE How are you feeling today, sir?

GEOFFREY Better, thank you. Just some painkillers, please.

Olivia steps out to take a call. The nurse lowers her voice and smiles.

NURSE Sir, I've worked here eleven years. I have never seen a woman take care of a man the way your woman takes care of you.

GEOFFREY *(quickly)* Ah, she's not my woman.

NURSE *(hands on hips)* Are you sure? She cooked that soup at five this morning. And she's slept in that chair two nights.

GEOFFREY We're… just friends.

NURSE *(leaving)* Hmm. Okay, sir. "Friends."

Olivia returns and sits. She is quiet for a moment.

OLIVIA I'm sorry. I put you in danger. You went to prison because of me.

GEOFFREY You didn't. *(beat)* My father taught me many wrong things. My mother taught me one right one: a man doesn't stand there while a woman is touched against her will. *(beat)* I'd do it again.

Her eyes fill up. She squeezes his hand.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 23 OF 38 · 17:50–18:20

The Escape From the Hospital

INT. HOSPITAL ROOM — NIGHT

> *Olivia picks up her bag.*

OLIVIA Tomorrow I'm going back to the prison. Alone. I'll see Mr. Lawal myself. You need to rest.

GEOFFREY *(trying to sit up)* No. No, I'm coming with you.

OLIVIA Geoffrey, you can barely sit up!

GEOFFREY I'm not letting you walk back into that place alone.

OLIVIA *(blushing slightly, firm)* You're staying in this bed. That's final. Goodnight.

> *She leaves. Later, the nurse turns off the light.*

NURSE Sleep now, sir. Doctor's orders.

> *The door closes. In the dark, Geoffrey's phone lights up his face. He looks at the drip in his arm, then at the door. He pulls the tape off and slides the drip out, wincing. He pulls on his clothes, limps to the window and slips out.*

↑ All scenes

SCENE 24 OF 38 · 18:20–19:48 TRUTH

Mr. Lawal

INT. AGODI CORRECTIONAL CENTRE — VISITING ROOM — NEXT MORNING

Olivia sits alone at a scratched table. The door opens behind her, and she turns. It's Geoffrey, pale, bruised and leaning on the door frame.

OLIVIA *(standing, shocked)* What are you doing here?! You're supposed to be in hospital!

GEOFFREY I told you. There's no way I'm letting you walk in here alone.

OLIVIA *(half angry, half melting)* You're impossible.

Another door opens. Two guards bring in MR. AYO LAWAL (60s), thin and grey in a faded prison uniform. He sits and squints at Olivia.

MR. LAWAL Who are you? What do you want from me?

OLIVIA *(softly)* I'm Olivia, sir. Elias Hart's daughter.

Mr. Lawal's face crumples. His hands shake.

MR. LAWAL Olivia? Little Olivia? *(He reaches for her hands.)* You've grown. You've grown so much. *(urgently)* Tell me you took your father's company back from that wicked man. Tell me you did it.

Olivia and Geoffrey freeze.

OLIVIA Which wicked man, sir?

MR. LAWAL Jacob Durose! *(His voice rises.)* When your father died, I went to tell the lawyers the papers had been changed. Jacob had me arrested first. Forged cheques in my desk. *(He's crying.)* Twenty-two years, my daughter, for a crime I never committed.

Silence. Olivia covers her mouth. Geoffrey stands up slowly.

OLIVIA *(gently)* Mr. Lawal. This is Geoffrey. *(beat)* Jacob's son.

Mr. Lawal stares at Geoffrey with fear, then anger. Geoffrey walks around the table, kneels on the prison floor in front of the old man and takes his shaking hands.

GEOFFREY Sir. I'm so sorry for what my father did to you. *(His voice breaks.)* I can't give you back twenty-two years. But I swear on my life, I'll get you out. Please forgive me.

A long, long silence. Then Mr. Lawal places a trembling hand on Geoffrey's head, like a blessing.

MR. LAWAL *(crying)* You're not your father, my son. *(beat)* Listen. Elias told me he'd finally make Jacob a partner, but I never saw the paper. And Jacob never destroyed anything. Too proud. Look in the old cabinet at his lodge in the Ogun forest.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 25 OF 38 · 19:48–20:26

A Hug in the Car Park

EXT. PRISON CAR PARK — DAY

> *Olivia helps Geoffrey toward the SUV. She is shaking with emotion.*

OLIVIA We have to get that old man out. Today. He's too old for that place.

GEOFFREY Of course. But first we need the documents, to prove my father forged—

OLIVIA *(stopping him)* No. The documents can wait. A man's life can't. *(beat)* My lawyer will get him out. And you're going back to that hospital. Right now.

GEOFFREY Olivia—

OLIVIA Your company matters, Geoffrey. Your father's name matters. But your life comes first.

> *Then, without warning, she wraps her arms around him in a quick, tight hug. She lets go and gets into the car before he can react.*

> *Geoffrey stands frozen in the car park, still feeling the hug.*

GEOFFREY *(whispering to himself)* Have I found my lady?

↑ All scenes

SCENE 26 OF 38 · 20:26–21:07

"The Way You Care For Him"

EXT. AGODI CORRECTIONAL CENTRE — GATE — EVENING — TWO DAYS LATER

> *The gate opens. Mr. Lawal walks out in new clothes and blinks at the sky. Olivia and Barrister Okonkwo wait for him. He grabs Olivia's hands.*

MR. LAWAL Free. After twenty-two years. God bless you, my daughter.

OLIVIA Thank Geoffrey. He's paying for your lawyer. And your house. And your pension.

MR. LAWAL *(studying her face, smiling)* Olivia. Are you sure there's nothing between you and that boy?

OLIVIA *(too fast)* What do you mean?

MR. LAWAL I'm an old man. I've been in a cell for twenty-two years. But I'm not blind. *(beat)* The way you two care for each other. That's not business. *(He pats her hand.)* Go to him. Life is too short to stay in prison by choice.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 27 OF 38 · 21:07–22:28 VOW TESTED

The Intruders

INT. GEOFFREY'S HOUSE — DAY — ONE WEEK LATER

> *Geoffrey, discharged and still bruised, unlocks his front door. Olivia is beside him, carrying his bag. She insisted on seeing him home safely. The door swings open. Donald and Michael are sitting in his living room.*

GEOFFREY *(startled)* Jesus! What are you doing in my house? How did you even get my key?

DONALD *(standing)* Is that really the question you should be asking right now? *(beat)* What happened to the business? Did you prove to this girl that it's yours?

GEOFFREY Donald, please. Stop it. Can't you see I'm not well?

DONALD I can see you've been gone two weeks and you've come home with HER.

OLIVIA *(stepping forward)* Is this how you talk to him? He just came out of hospital. He deserves respect. *(beat)* And what business are you talking about? What do you mean "OUR" business?

> *Donald stares at her. Then he laughs coldly.*

DONALD Oh. You didn't tell her? *(to Geoffrey)* You didn't tell her we're partners? I suppose you were busy falling in love.

GEOFFREY *(shaking)* Donald. Get out of my house.

DONALD *(to Olivia)* That company isn't yours yet. And if you think you can use your father's business to get to us through Geoffrey's soft heart, it won't happen.

MICHAEL *(grabbing Donald's arm)* Okay. Okay, Donald, it's enough. Let's go. Let's go NOW.

> *Michael pulls Donald toward the door. Geoffrey catches Michael's sleeve.*

GEOFFREY *(low, hurt)* How did you allow this, Michael?

MICHAEL *(sadly)* Brother, I don't know what's wrong with Donald these days.

> *They leave. The door shuts. Silence.*

↑ All scenes

SCENE 28 OF 38 · 22:28–23:25 VOW TESTED

"What Vow?"

INT. GEOFFREY'S HOUSE — CONTINUOUS

OLIVIA *(quietly)* What vow, Geoffrey? What partnership? *(beat)* Tell me the truth.

GEOFFREY *(sitting heavily)* Donald and Michael own part of Durose through our partnership. The court froze them too. *(beat)* And years ago, the three of us vowed on a rooftop never to fall in love.

> *Olivia goes very still.*

OLIVIA So all this time, when you defended me, gave me your shoes, went to prison for me… you were what? Keeping your vow? Protecting your partners' money?

GEOFFREY No. Olivia, that's not—

OLIVIA *(standing, her voice breaking)* Do you think I WANTED to fall in love with you? With Jacob Durose's son? *(beat)* Is that how you've been looking at me? As a threat to your vow? A woman trying to "get to you"?

GEOFFREY *(standing)* Olivia, please—

> *She walks out. He limps after her to the gate, but her BODYGUARD steps between them.*

BODYGUARD Sir. Madam said no.

> *The SUV drives away. Geoffrey stands at his gate, alone again.*

↑ All scenes

SCENE 29 OF 38 · 23:25–24:49 VOW TESTED

Michael Comes

INT. GEOFFREY'S HOUSE — NIGHT — DAYS LATER

Curtains closed, food untouched. Geoffrey hasn't left the house in days. Michael lets himself in and sits beside him.

MICHAEL I'm sorry, brother. For Donald. For everything he said.

GEOFFREY *(staring at nothing)* It's fine. It's what I signed up for, isn't it? I made a vow. This is what it costs.

MICHAEL No. We made that vow like hungry boys from Ajegunle, afraid of losing anything. We didn't grow up with love. We grew up with hardship.

GEOFFREY *(slowly turning)* What are you trying to say, Michael?

MICHAEL We're getting old. We've worked hard. We need a little love in our lives.

GEOFFREY *(staring at him)* Michael. Please don't tell me you've found a woman.

MICHAEL *(smiling)* I've found one. Her name is Sophia. She shows me love. She completes me. I don't know how she does it, but she makes my whole life turn. *(beat)* I'd sell my studio tomorrow for her.

GEOFFREY *(stunned)* "Script Supervisor." *(beat)* Does Donald know?

MICHAEL Not yet. And don't you tell him. *(beat)* Donald is scared, Geoffrey. That's his wahala, not yours. Don't let his fear make your decisions. *(He stands.)* Where is Olivia right now?

GEOFFREY *(a sudden realisation)* ...She said she'd look for the documents. Alone. At my father's lodge. *(He grabs his keys.)* Michael, that lodge has been empty for years. There are wild dogs in that forest.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 30 OF 38 · 24:49–25:01

The Lodge

EXT/INT. JACOB DUROSE'S LODGE, OGUN FOREST — NIGHT

An old, abandoned lodge deep in the forest, with dust everywhere. Olivia pushes the creaking door open with her phone torch. In the study, a tall old wooden cabinet stands in the corner. She pulls its doors open.

A deep growl comes from the dark space beside the cabinet. A HUGE DOG, as big as a calf and starving, rises slowly, its teeth bared and its eyes shining in the torchlight.

OLIVIA *(backing away, whispering)* No. No, no, no...

The dog lunges. Olivia screams and runs, through the corridor and out the back door into the trees, with the dog barking and snapping right behind her.

Headlights sweep the trees as Geoffrey's car skids to a stop outside. He hears her scream and runs into the lodge. By the door, in an old umbrella stand, is his father's heavy carved walking stick. He grabs it.

Olivia trips on a root and falls hard. The dog leaps at her—

Geoffrey jumps between them, swinging the heavy stick with a roar. CRACK. It slams into the ground right in front of the dog's face. He swings again and again, shouting and standing over her.

GEOFFREY GET BACK! GET AWAY FROM HER!

The huge dog yelps, turns and runs off into the dark forest. Silence. Olivia lies on the ground, shaking. Geoffrey stands over her, breathing hard, with the walking stick still raised.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 31 OF 38 · 25:01–25:49

After the Chase

EXT. LODGE — BACK GARDEN — CONTINUOUS

> *Geoffrey drops the stick and kneels beside her. He checks her arms and her face.*

GEOFFREY Are you hurt? Did it bite you? Olivia, talk to me!

OLIVIA *(shaking)* I'm okay. I'm okay. *(beat)* What are you doing here? *(She looks at the stick on the grass.)* And since when are you a lion?

GEOFFREY *(quietly, picking up the stick)* It's my father's. He used it every day of his old age. He always said, "A Durose must protect what is his." *(beat)* For once, I agree with him.

OLIVIA *(crying now)* I'm sorry. For walking out. For what I said.

GEOFFREY I'm sorry I was stupid enough to let you come here alone.

> *He helps her up. Without a word, they hold each other in a tight, silent hug in the moonlight.*

GEOFFREY *(whispering)* I hope you're okay.

OLIVIA *(against his shoulder)* I am now. *(beat)* The cabinet. Whatever your father hid, it's in that cabinet.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 32 OF 38 · 25:49–27:42 TRUTH

The Truth

INT. LODGE — STUDY — NIGHT

At the bottom of the old wooden cabinet, Geoffrey pulls up a loose wooden panel. Underneath is a steel box. Inside are two papers and an old VHS tape labelled in Jacob's handwriting: "FOR GEOFFREY. WHEN I'M GONE."

They play it on an old TV and VCR in the corner. JACOB DUROSE, older and tired, sits in this same room and speaks to the camera.

JACOB DUROSE (ON TAPE) Geoffrey. If you're watching this, you've found the truth. *(beat)* Elias Hart owned this company. I was his clerk for fifteen years. I missed your birthdays for him. Every December he promised me shares, and every December he gave me nothing.

JACOB DUROSE (ON TAPE) When his heart failed at his desk, I didn't kill him, my son. God is my witness. But I felt cheated. Fifteen years, and not a kobo. So that same night, I changed the papers. I made it one hundred percent Durose, as if it had always been mine. When his assistant tried to stop me, I sent an innocent man to prison. And once, I slapped a little girl who saw me.

Olivia's hand goes to her mouth.

JACOB DUROSE (ON TAPE) *(holding up a paper to the camera)* Then, weeks later, clearing his desk, I found this. A new certificate. Signed by Elias the week he died. Sixty percent Hart. Forty percent Durose. *(His voice breaks.)* He'd finally had a change of heart. He was going to give me forty percent. He just never lived to tell me.

JACOB DUROSE (ON TAPE) I stole sixty percent from a man who had finally decided to be fair. And I was too proud and too ashamed to undo it. *(beat)* I gave you everything, Geoffrey. Except the truth. I'm sorry.

The tape crackles to static. Geoffrey lifts the two papers out of the box. One is the real certificate: "ELIAS HART — 60% · JACOB DUROSE — 40%", with Elias's signature. Under it is a copy of the forged certificate: "JACOB DUROSE — 100%".

OLIVIA *(very softly)* Sixty, forty. *(beat)* So Papa did mean to give him something.

GEOFFREY And my father had a right to forty percent. Not a hundred.

OLIVIA We were both wrong, Geoffrey. You thought it was all yours. I thought your father had no right to anything.

GEOFFREY *(staring at the two papers)* Our fathers lied to us from both sides.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 33 OF 38 · 27:42–29:43

Seventy, Thirty

INT. LODGE — STUDY — CONTINUOUS

Dawn light creeps through the dusty window. They sit on the floor beside the cabinet with the real certificate between them.

OLIVIA So legally, sixty percent of Durose Holdings belongs to the Hart family. To me.

GEOFFREY Sixty percent of the company as it was in 1996. Two offices and four trucks. *(beat)* I've run it for twelve years, Olivia. It's forty times bigger now. My sweat is in it. My brothers' money is in it. Hundreds of families eat from it.

OLIVIA And my father's name was scraped off it.

GEOFFREY I know. And I won't defend that. But I won't pretend I didn't build it either.

OLIVIA *(folding her arms)* Fifty-fifty.

GEOFFREY Eighty-twenty.

OLIVIA *(laughing in disbelief)* Eighty? Your father forged it!

GEOFFREY And I didn't. *(beat)* Seventy-thirty. Seventy for the man who built it into what it is today. Thirty for the man who started it. And his name goes back on the gate, beside my father's.

She thinks about it for a long time.

OLIVIA Seventy-thirty. *(beat)* And Hart goes first on the gate.

GEOFFREY *(after a beat, smiling)* …Hart and Durose.

They shake hands. Then she doesn't let go of his hand.

OLIVIA And my thirty percent, I don't want it.

GEOFFREY What?

OLIVIA I have more than I can spend. My thirty percent goes to charity. The Elias Hart Foundation, for children who grew up like you did in Ajegunle. *(beat)* And it looks after Mr. Lawal for the rest of his life. Twenty-two years. It's the least my father's name owes him.

Geoffrey is deeply moved.

GEOFFREY We've settled the company. *(beat)* But there's one thing I can't put a percentage on.

OLIVIA What?

GEOFFREY You. *(beat)* Tell me you don't see what I see. We grew up in the same lies, Olivia. You're the first true thing I've ever found.

OLIVIA *(tears falling)* You don't mean it. You made a vow.

GEOFFREY I don't care about any vow. *(beat)* I'd walk barefoot from here to Lagos. *(softly)* I mean it with everything I have.

OLIVIA *(whispering)* You mean that?

GEOFFREY Yes.

> *No more words are needed. She walks into his arms, and they hold each other in a long, tight hug as the sun comes up through the dusty window.*

↑ All scenes

SCENE 34 OF 38 · 29:43–30:59 VOW TESTED

The Promise Kept

INT. THREE BOYS VENTURES — BOARDROOM — DAY

Donald sits at the head of the table and Michael on the side. Geoffrey walks in, calm, with a leather folder. Donald stands.

DONALD I hope you've come with good news.

GEOFFREY I have. I promised you I'd get the company back. *(He slides the folder across.)* The court has lifted the seal. The banks have unfrozen us. Every naira you two put in is safe.

MICHAEL *(jumping up)* GEOFFREY! *(He grabs him in a hug.)* I knew it!

DONALD *(reading the papers, slowly)* Seventy percent Durose. Thirty percent Hart. *(He looks up.)* So the company wasn't all your father's.

GEOFFREY No. Elias Hart founded it, and he'd meant to give my father forty percent before he died. My father took a hundred instead. *(beat)* Olivia and I agreed on seventy-thirty, for twelve years of my work. The company will be called Hart and Durose. And her thirty percent goes to charity, to the Elias Hart Foundation.

DONALD *(stunned)* She gave away thirty percent? Just like that?

GEOFFREY She only ever wanted the truth, Donald. You thought she wanted to get to us. She didn't.

Donald looks down, ashamed, and says nothing.

GEOFFREY And one more thing. *(He takes a breath.)* I broke the vow. I'm in love with Olivia Hart.

Silence. Michael grins. Donald slowly closes the folder, stands, and walks out of the boardroom without a word.

MICHAEL *(calling after him)* Donald! *(beat; to Geoffrey, softly)* Give him time. He's not fighting you, brother. He's fighting himself.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 35 OF 38 · 30:59–31:29

Hart & Durose

MONTAGE — LAGOS — WEEKS LATER

> *Michael and Sophia on the beach at Badagry, laughing as she reads him a new script and he actually listens.*

> *The headquarters gate in Ikoyi. Workers lift a huge new sign into place: "HART & DUROSE HOLDINGS — FOUNDED 1996 BY ELIAS HART & JACOB DUROSE." Staff clap. Mr. Lawal, in a new suit, wipes his eyes. Mrs. Durose holds Olivia's hand. Geoffrey cuts the ribbon, still the boss and still running the company he built.*

> *Inside, a big cheque reads "THE ELIAS HART FOUNDATION — 30% OF HART & DUROSE HOLDINGS." Olivia signs it with a smile.*

> *Days later, Olivia visits the office. Geoffrey opens every door for her and brings her amala on Fridays. Colleagues whisper and smile.*

AMAKA *(Olivia's PA, leaning in)* Madam, I see the way you care for him. Like he hung the moon.

OLIVIA *(smiling)* You know I do, Amaka.

> *EXT. LAGOON — SUNSET. A small boat, Olivia's island and a table for two. Geoffrey kneels on the sand with a simple ring.*

GEOFFREY Our fathers gave us a company full of lies. I want to give you a home full of truth. *(beat)* Olivia Hart, will you marry me?

OLIVIA *(laughing and crying)* On my own island? Yes. Yes!

↑ All scenes

SCENE 36 OF 38 · 31:29–31:52

The Knock

INT. GEOFFREY'S HOUSE, BANANA ISLAND — NIGHT

> *Geoffrey and Olivia are on the sofa watching TV, her feet in his lap. A knock. Geoffrey opens the door. It's Donald, alone and nervous.*

GEOFFREY *(surprised)* Donald. What are you doing here?

DONALD I need to talk to you and Michael. Properly. Can we meet at the office tomorrow?

GEOFFREY *(after a beat)* Yes. No problem. I'll come.

> *INT. MICHAEL'S HOUSE — SAME NIGHT. Michael opens his door to Donald. Sophia waves from the kitchen.*

MICHAEL Donald?

DONALD Tomorrow. The office. Please.

MICHAEL *(studying him)* Okay. Sure, I'll come.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 37 OF 38 · 31:52–33:28 VOW TESTED

Cheers to a New Chapter

INT. THREE BOYS VENTURES — BOARDROOM — NEXT DAY

Three chairs and three glasses. Donald pours the drinks himself, something he has never done.

DONALD I walked out on you, Geoffrey. When you kept your promise and saved all of us. *(beat)* And I owe you an apology. What I said to Olivia, I'll be ashamed of forever.

GEOFFREY *(quietly)* You were scared.

DONALD I was controlling. That's what I do when I'm scared. It took nearly losing my brothers to hear it.

MICHAEL So let's tell it all. Properly. No more secrets.

DONALD I'll go first. *(He takes a breath.)* There's a woman. Emma Reardon. A girl with a red pen who told me my report was the problem. I've been hiding her from you both for months. *(beat)* Best thing I ever broke.

MICHAEL *(grinning)* Size thirty-eight heel.

DONALD *(pointing at him)* Script Supervisor!

GEOFFREY *(quietly)* I knew about both of you. For months.

MICHAEL I broke it for a writer who sat in my chair and told me I was in her story. *(beat)* She was right.

GEOFFREY I broke it for a woman who called my father a thief. *(beat)* She was right too.

They burst out laughing, three liars caught at once, and really laugh for the first time in months.

DONALD We made that vow as hungry boys in grown men's suits. So afraid of losing anything, we promised never to have anything worth losing.

GEOFFREY There's more to life than chasing goals. We can still be bosses. *(beat)* And husbands. Fathers. A legacy that isn't just a building.

MICHAEL *(raising his glass)* Then cheers. To a new chapter.

DONALD & GEOFFREY To a new chapter.

Three glasses clink.

↑ All scenes

SCENE 38 OF 38 · 33:28 — END VOW TESTED

The New Vow

EXT. THE OLD AJEGUNLE ROOFTOP — SUNSET — SIX MONTHS LATER

Quick flashes first. Geoffrey and Olivia's wedding, with Mr. Lawal walking Olivia down the aisle and Mrs. Durose crying in the front row. Michael kneeling to Sophia on Badagry beach as she screams "YES!". Donald and Emma carrying boxes into their new home, laughing.

Then the rooftop. Fairy lights and three leather chairs. Emma, Sophia and Olivia sit on the steps sharing suya and laughing. Donald, Michael and Geoffrey stand at the edge where three hungry boys once sat. Geoffrey holds a bottle. He pours some of the drink onto the old zinc, a libation.

GEOFFREY *(looking down at the zinc)* To young Donald, young Michael and young Geoffrey. We're sorry. We couldn't keep the vow you made.

MICHAEL We made it when we were foolish. We thought love would make us weak.

DONALD Now we know better. We want to make you proud. A home full of love and truth will do that.

GEOFFREY *(turning to them)* So let's make a new vow. Here. Where it all began. *(He raises his glass.)* From today, we vow to always be happy. And to only do the things that make us, and the people we love, truly happy.

MICHAEL I subscribe to that.

DONALD *(smiling)* Yes. Let's go with that.

ALL THREE Sworn.

Three glasses clink. Behind them, the three women cheer. Olivia runs to Geoffrey and hugs him tight.

The camera rises slowly from the rooftop, over the zinc roofs of Ajegunle, over the lagoon and up into the golden Lagos sky.

THE SWORN BACHELORS. THE END.

END

↑ All scenes